

PLAYGROUNDS

Playgrounds at Loudoun County Public Schools (LCPS) provide important cognitive and physical benefits to LCPS students and are commonly used during recess by students and by the public during non-school hours. This regulation applies to all playgrounds installed during new construction, playground additions or modifications, and playground replacements.

A. Applicable Playground Rules, Guidelines, and Standards. All LCPS playgrounds are subject to appropriate safety standards related to both playground equipment and playground surfacing, as well as accessibility requirements.

1. Consumer Product Safety Commission (CPSC). LCPS follows the guidelines set forth in the CPSC *Public Playground Safety Handbook* for both equipment and playground surfacing. The CPSC handbook is aligned with several ASTM standards described below.

2. American Society for Testing and Materials (ASTM). Several different ASTM standards provide important processes and specifications relating to various aspects of playgrounds. LCPS follows these standards for safety. Specific standards include, but are not limited to, Standard F1292-22: *Standard Specification for Impact Attenuation of Surfacing Materials within the Use Zone of Playground Equipment*, Standard F1487-21: *Standard Consumer Safety Performance Specifications for Playground Equipment for Public Use*, Standard F2075-20: *Standard Specification for Engineered Wood Fiber for Use as a Playground Safety Surface Under and Around Playground Equipment*, and Standard F2223-19a: *Standard Guide for ASTM Standards on Playground Surfacing*.

3. Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) and Related Guidance. LCPS ensures that all playgrounds comply with the ADA. In the design of inclusive playgrounds, LCPS draws on the guidelines and information provided by the U.S. Access Board.

4. Manufacturer Equipment Certifications. LCPS complies with the above standards, as independently certified by IPEMA or the vendor. Additional verification may also be completed by LCPS staff.

5. State Requirements. LCPS playgrounds comply with the *Guidelines for School Facilities in Virginia's Public Schools*, published by the Virginia Department of Education.

B. Inclusive Playgrounds.

1. Inclusive playgrounds are not only accessible, but provide a common place for students of all abilities to play in the same location together.

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2. An inclusive playground will be installed as part of new elementary school construction and for any playground replacement projects. An inclusive playground will also be installed as part of new high school construction if programs related to preschool instruction are included in the instructional plans for the facility.

3. In addition to the minimum equipment standard as identified in this regulation, overall design for inclusive playgrounds must be aligned with the US Access Board guidelines pertaining to playgrounds.

C. Design and Construction.

1. Minimum Equipment Standard. The minimum equipment standards below will be used in new school playground construction, as well as playground replacements, to ensure that each school has a minimum standard of equipment. If, during a replacement, a playground remaining at the school meets the minimum standard, the replacement playground does not also have to meet the standard.

- a. Across all playgrounds on each elementary or relevant high school's campus, there must be at least one slide, at least one climbing structure or component, and at least one balancing structure or component. This minimum standard facilitates varied play experiences.
- b. Inclusive Playground Design Guidance for all new and replacement playgrounds funded through LCPS:
 - i. Unitary poured-in-place rubber surfacing must be used.
 - ii. A range of challenges for students of all relevant ages and abilities should be incorporated into designs.
 - iii. Accessible routes must be available to ground level or ramp-accessible equipment.
 - iv. A ramped component structure is recommended to allow students to easily access some elevated components.
 - v. If one or more slides are included and at least one slide elevated above ramp level for a more significant challenge, a lower, ramp-accessible slide must also be present. If no other playgrounds are present on campus, at least one slide must be included in the inclusive playground.
 - vi. At least one motion-oriented piece of equipment that can be used by those in wheelchairs or with mobility devices without leaving that chair or device must be included.

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- vii. Music or other sensory components are recommended.
- viii. If standard belt swings are included, at least one harnessed or restricted seat on the same swing frame must be provided. Disc swings are also permissible.
- ix. A variety of play panels are recommended to provide a range of activities for all students.
- x. Located within a fenced-in area with gates.

2. Playground Surfacing. All playgrounds installed with LCPS-managed funding must be inclusive and therefore, have poured-in-place rubber surfacing. Playgrounds funded with outside funding must have poured-in-place rubber surfacing. When possible, borders around playground surfacing should be made of plastic to promote durability and safety. All playgrounds must have a ramp or pathway that is ADA accessible.

3. Marking. All playground equipment must be marked with the appropriate age range for safe use. Playgrounds should also include labels and signs to identify characteristics of responsible equipment use and requirement for adult supervision while using the playground.

4. Vendor Requirements and Oversight. The LCPS Department of Support Services will oversee all playground projects, regardless of the source of funding for the playground. Upon installation of an approved playground or new playground equipment, all vendors must provide documentation from a Certified Playground Safety Inspector stating that the equipment and surfacing was installed in compliance with ASTM and CPSC guidelines and is accessible per ADA before the playground can be opened for use.

5. New School Construction.

- a. LCPS will provide an inclusive playground suitable for ages 5-12 at all new elementary schools and an inclusive playground suitable for ages 2-5 at all high schools with a preschool program.
- b. The LCPS Department of Support Services holds primary responsibility for the design and construction of playgrounds built at new schools as part of the initial facility construction, as well as for all playground replacement projects. Support Services will develop a standard design that will be used for new and replacement playgrounds. This standard design may evolve over time, given

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innovations in playground equipment and design. Principals may assist in choosing the color for their respective playgrounds. The Department of Support Services will provide the relevant equipment standard to the vendor during the design process, oversee all siting and installation, obtain verification of ASTM and CPSC compliance for both equipment and surfacing as proposed, and obtain a final report that both were installed per guidelines for each playground installed.

6. Additional or Modified Playgrounds at Existing Schools.

- a. Where space permits, LCPS allows the addition or modification of existing playground facilities at schools that have already been constructed. This can include additional playground pads, expansion of existing playground pads, or enhancement through additional equipment on existing pads, space permitting.
- b. Any additional play equipment installed through outside funding is required to have poured-in-place surfacing and be ADA compliant, including access to the play equipment.
- c. Additional play equipment installed through outside funding is not the responsibility of LCPS and will be removed if not replaced by outside funding when it reaches end of life.
- b. All playground equipment and surfacing installed on LCPS property, regardless of funding source, is the sole property of LCPS.
- c. The LCPS Department of Support Services holds primary responsibility for coordinating the playground review and installation process for all playgrounds built at existing schools.
 - i. Schools must submit a work order and package to the Department of Support Services for review and gain approval before the project begins. LCPS playground reviews consider accessibility, compliance with guidelines and standards, proposed playground equipment, surfacing type and depth, borders, walkways, ramps, siting, grading, and drainage, if needed. Playground project proposals must include each of these items. The Department of Support Services also coordinates with Procurement to verify contracts associated with playground vendors. All playground projects must be formally approved by the Department of Support Services.

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- ii. The Department of Support Services provides project management for all playground additions or modifications, including oversight of installation.
 - iii. The Department of Support Services gathers information confirming ASTM and CPSC compliance for both equipment and surfacing and obtains a final report that both were installed per guidelines for each playground or modification installed.
 - iii. All playground modification or addition requests must be made by school administrators. The Department of Support Services Coordination advises principals on the playground addition or modification process.
 - iv. All contracts for material and/or labor must be signed by the Department of Support Services. School administrators shall submit any necessary documentation to the Department of Support Services. Community organization funding must be paid through LCPS per LCPS guidance, not paid directly to a vendor.
- d. LCPS, when replacing existing playgrounds through the Capital Asset Preservation Program (CAPP), the Capital Improvement Plan (CIP), proffer funding, or operations and maintenance funding, will install the LCPS standard inclusive playground design at the time of the replacement.

D. Playground Maintenance.

1. Inspections. LCPS undertakes a regular inspection program, including daily, annual, and as-needed inspections to ensure safety on all playgrounds.
 - a. Daily inspections should be provided by school staff to identify accessibility or usability issues, hazards, and equipment requiring repair. School staff, through Custodial Services, should rake and fluff engineered wood fiber to maintain appropriate surfacing distribution and depth.
 - b. LCPS will perform comprehensive safety inspections annually and as needed when conditions warrant or potential hazards are noted.
2. Repairs. School staff should submit work orders for any needed repairs, which will be performed or coordinated through LCPS Facilities Services. Equipment use should be restricted from both students and the public, if necessary, until repairs are

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complete. If parts cannot be located, LCPS may remove equipment components or replace them with a similar type of component.

E. Playground Life Cycle Management.

1. LCPS will track and manage the life cycle of all playgrounds.
2. The Department of Support Services holds primary responsibility for managing the life cycle of LCPS playgrounds.
3. LCPS will replace one standard inclusive playground per campus in whole or in part through life cycle management. Other playground equipment is not the responsibility of LCPS to replace and will be removed if not replaced by outside funding when it reaches end of life.
4. Replacements will be planned through the CIP, CAPP, or other methods. Prioritizing replacement is based on need. Several factors will be used to guide prioritization for replacement, including:
 - a. Equipment and surfacing condition
 - b. Compliance with ASTM and CPSC guidance
 - c. Appropriateness of equipment for ages of students using equipment
 - d. Variety of play experiences
5. Playgrounds scheduled for replacement may change based on changing needs, condition, practices, or funding.
6. When a school is scheduled for a playground replacement, the school may fundraise to supplement the funding provided by LCPS, enhancing the amount available for replacement. The ability to expand playground area is contingent on space available. The full funding amount, including both the fixed LCPS portion and the additional fundraised portion, must be sufficient to cover all equipment, surfacing, borders, ramps, and any site improvements or drainage needed.
7. Review processes for playground expansions made through life cycle replacements, partially funded by schools or outside organizations, will be the same as described in Section C of this regulation pertaining to Additional or Modified Playgrounds at Existing Schools.

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